

barracks. The embassies of the Philippines and South Korea, America's allies in the war, were also attacked.

Using sappers (engineers) to blast their way through fortified walls and front gates, the Viet Cong managed to breach most of these compounds quickly. Their task was made easier by the leisurely pace at which ARVN troops returned from their leave and the fact that few US combat troops were based in Saigon. The vast majority of American combat units were stationed up north where much of the fighting had taken place over the previous six months. Although an intervention by General Weyand had boosted the number of troops in the wider Saigon area, the city center was held by the undermanned ARVN Fifth Rangers and a small detachment of Marines guarding the US Embassy. Most of the US personnel remaining in Saigon were administrative staff rather than battle-hardened combat troops.

Using weapons smuggled into the city inside coffins and delivery trucks in the months leading up to Tet, the Viet Cong assembled in local hotels where they stayed under the guise of holiday visitors. Some were clad in civilian clothes, others dressed in stolen ARVN uniforms. Exiting their assembly points, the Viet Cong waylaid private cars and taxis to reach their targets. Along the way, they gunned down South Vietnamese police or American Military Police unfortunate enough to stray into their path.

Nearly overrun by the surprise attack, US and ARVN personnel grabbed any weapons they could find and hastily created defensive positions in offices, barracks, and supply rooms. Westmoreland and his staff were forced to take refuge in his command bunkers in the MACV compound. As the fighting around the US headquarters intensified, the general's staff drew their arms and joined the last-ditch defense. In a move indicative of the dire situation, Westmoreland mandated that many of the duties of the central command should be immediately transferred to the US Army headquarters in Long Binh.

“An earth-shattering, mind-shattering event
that **changed the course of the war.**”

NAVAL WAR COLLEGE HISTORIAN JAMES J. WIRTZ, 2004